

THE

WATER



WARDENS

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Dr Thinkmore is our hero. A while ago she organised a field trip for us to the marine reserve at Leigh in Northland. Now we've invited her back to Area 5 to share in our follow-up presentation.

The walls of our classroom are covered with diagrams of the seashore, population graphs, and murals of the amazing sea life at Leigh. "Wonderful work!" exclaims Dr Thinkmore. "Now, I'm really interested to hear about your group studies."

Priyesh stands and begins. "Our group found out about how to set up a marine reserve. It takes loads of work ... ummm ..." He glances at his notes. "Usually a conservation group starts things up. But a marine reserve doesn't become law till the whole community agrees. You need to convince the people who fish for a living that it's a good idea. But they often agree because they know that marine reserves help to build up the sea life in nearby fishing grounds."

"Yeah, we talked to some guys unloading crates of big, fat crayfish just down the coast," adds Toni. "They think the reserve's great!"

"Often the hardest people to convince are the ones who fish for fun," says Connor. "My dad's one of them,



and he reckons it's his right to fish off the rocks. But I tell him that a marine reserve means more fish for everyone. I think he agrees now – kind of."

"Yes, you're right, sometimes attitudes take a while to change." Dr Thinkmore looks around the room.

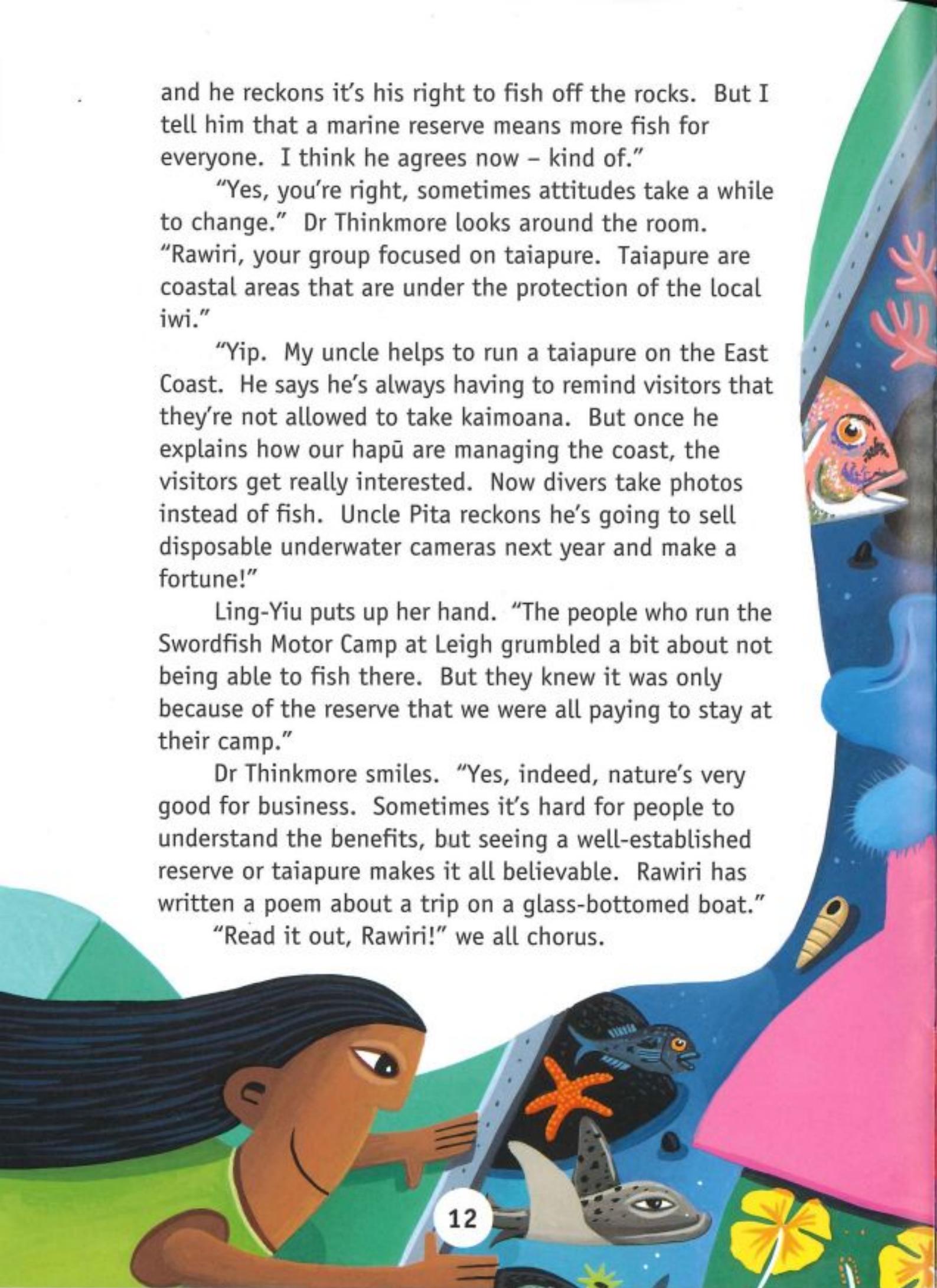
"Rawiri, your group focused on taiapure. Taiapure are coastal areas that are under the protection of the local iwi."

"Yip. My uncle helps to run a taiapure on the East Coast. He says he's always having to remind visitors that they're not allowed to take kaimoana. But once he explains how our hapū are managing the coast, the visitors get really interested. Now divers take photos instead of fish. Uncle Pita reckons he's going to sell disposable underwater cameras next year and make a fortune!"

Ling-Yiu puts up her hand. "The people who run the Swordfish Motor Camp at Leigh grumbled a bit about not being able to fish there. But they knew it was only because of the reserve that we were all paying to stay at their camp."

Dr Thinkmore smiles. "Yes, indeed, nature's very good for business. Sometimes it's hard for people to understand the benefits, but seeing a well-established reserve or taiapure makes it all believable. Rawiri has written a poem about a trip on a glass-bottomed boat."

"Read it out, Rawiri!" we all chorus.





There are moki and snapper,
blue maomao and brill.
We see amazing sea life
when the waters are still.

The crayfish are growing
ever so large.
They know they're safe here
when Pita's in charge!

"The fish are worth
thousands of dollars," he said.
"Thousands more dollars
alive here than dead."

"Don't feed the fish
or wear studs in your nose.
If the fish think you're food,
they'll bite at your toes!"

After lunch, we're all keen to tell Dr Thinkmore about our own conservation project. Riria's hand is waving wildly in the air. "We've adopted a stream, Miss. It's called Kokopu Stream. At least, that's what we call it. We used to catch fish there, and once I took one home in a bucket. My cousin Tina got really excited when she saw it. 'That's a kokopu,' she said. 'They're rare, you know! You'd better take it back.' She's studying to be an ecologist, so I did what she said."

"Adopting a stream can be a great project," says Dr Thinkmore. "Have you thought about clearing out rubbish and planting trees nearby?"

"We had a clean out once. We took sacks down there to get all the rubbish. Astrid picked up an old gumboot and tipped out an eel! We put the gumboot back because we decided that if it was an eel house, it didn't count as rubbish."

Astrid's hand shoots up. "And we wondered about planting trees, too. There's lots of watercress. Last time we were down there, I picked some for Nan. But there's also heaps of blackberry and gorse everywhere."

"Tina reckons gorse isn't all bad," says Riria. "It's actually good for the soil because it adds nitrogen. After the gorse has been there for a while, other plants can take over from it and grow on in healthy soil."

Dr Thinkmore knows a good opportunity when she sees one. "Supposing I could organise a class visit to Kokopu Stream in school time – would you, as guardians of the stream, give me permission? I'd be very keen for us to test the water by counting the insect life. For example, we could look carefully for mayfly nymphs. If we can find them, we'll know that the water's pure, because mayflies can only survive in very clean water."

Everyone chimes in with ideas. "We could plant trees, too." "Maybe the local nursery would donate some." "We could even grow saplings at school." "Do you think Tina would want to join in with the project?"

Dr Thinkmore is getting excited too. "Perhaps we could plant lots of gorse and scatter gumboots everywhere!" Everyone looks surprised, and a wry smile creeps across Dr Thinkmore's face. "Just kidding."

